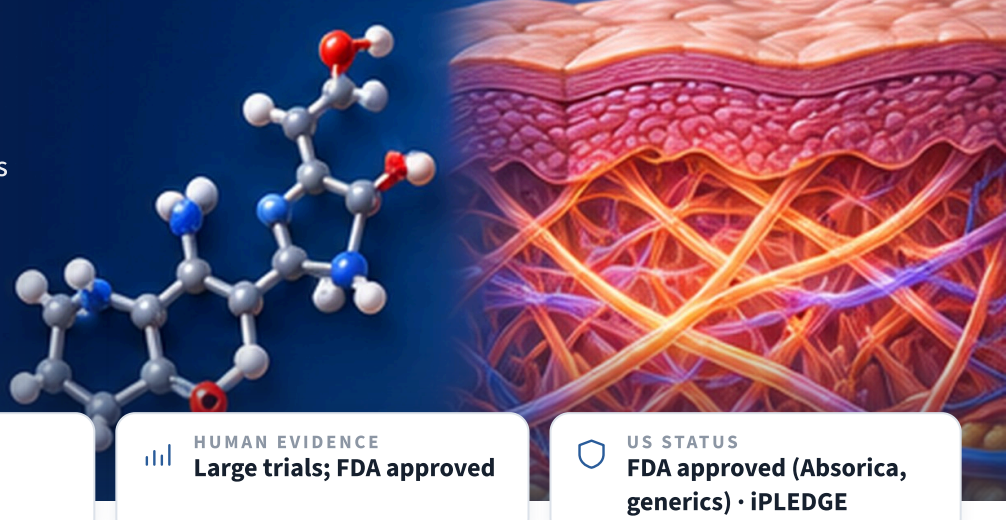
SKIN 12

Isotretinoin

Retinoid (related to vitamin A) taken by mouth as capsules



CLASS Retinoid

STUDIED FOR Severe nodular acne

HUMAN EVIDENCE Large trials; FDA approved

US STATUS FDA approved (Absorica, generics) · iPLEDGE

STUDIED FOR

Severe nodular acne	Sperm
HUMAN	HUMAN + ANIMAL

Sold only through iPLEDGE. All US isotretinoin goes through a restricted program (REMS) because it can cause severe birth defects.

HOW IT WORKS IN THE BODY

Isotretinoin ▶ Oil glands ▶ Less sebum ▶ Fewer nodules

- **Retinoid** that inhibits sebaceous gland function and keratinization (label)
- **Less oil (sebum)** goes along with improvement; the drop is temporary (label)
- **The exact mechanism** in nodular acne is unknown (label)

EVIDENCE & WHAT'S KNOWN

EVIDENCE

FDA APPROVED
LEVEL 5 OF 5

- Absorica: 925-person randomized trial, 20 weeks
- No placebo group in that trial
- Approved since 1982 (Accutane)

NOT YET ESTABLISHED

- Cause of reported sexual effects
- Cause of reported mood effects
- Cause of hearing loss

QUICK PRACTICAL INFO

HALF-LIFE
18 hours (Absorica); 4-oxo metabolite 38 hours

ROUTES STUDIED
By mouth (capsules)

PHARMACOKINETICS
Peak 2.9 h fasting, 6.4 h fed; CYP2C8, 2C9, 3A4, 2B6 (in vitro)

SOLD AS
Prescription capsules (Absorica, generics) via iPLEDGE

MONITORED IN TRIALS
Pregnancy tests, fasting lipids, liver tests, mood, vision

SPORT (WADA)
Not on the 2026 list

REGULATORY

FDA	Approved 1982; boxed warning on birth defects
FDA	iPLEDGE REMS; 2026 changes due Nov 15, 2026
MHRA	Checks of mood and sexual function at each visit
WADA	Not listed

REFERENCES

1. FDA, Absorica / Absorica LD prescribing information, Aug 2026
2. FDA, iPLEDGE REMS, Jun 2026
3. MHRA, Isotretinoin: changes to prescribing guidance, Jan 2026

Adonis Men's Health · checked Nov 2026. Research and regulator records only. Not medical advice.

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